

The Man at Table Seven

Book 2 of 10

Every morning, the same man. The same table. But never any food.

CEFR Level A1 | Adult Graded Reader

Setting: A busy café in London. Table seven is near the window.

Genre: Light Mystery / City Drama

Characters

- Joe - 28. Waiter. Curious and friendly.
- Martin - About 55. Comes every morning. Sits at table seven. Always orders only water.
- Dana - 25. The other waiter. Practical and direct.
- Lena - The woman Martin is waiting for.

The Man at Table Seven

The café opens at seven. Joe puts the chairs down, wipes the tables, turns on the coffee machine. At seven forty-five, the man comes in - always at seven forty-five. He always sits at table seven, near the window. Joe knows his face. He knows his grey coat and old brown leather bag. But he does not know his name.

'Good morning. What would you like?' 'Water, please. Just water.' Joe brings a glass of water. The man says thank you. The man does not eat. He does not drink coffee. He just sits and looks out of the window. At nine o'clock he stands up, puts on his coat, and leaves. 'Only water,' Joe says to himself. 'Every day. Only water.'

'I think he is waiting for someone,' Dana says. 'Every day?' 'Yes. Look at him - he always looks at the street. Not at the café. At the street.' Joe looks. Dana is right. The man's eyes are always on the street outside. 'But nobody comes,' Joe says. Dana shrugs. 'Not yet,' she says.

On Thursday, Joe puts the water on the table and stays. 'Excuse me. I am Joe. You come here every day. But you never eat or drink coffee.' 'I

The Man at Table Seven



Martin sits alone at table seven, looking out at the street.

know. I am sorry. I just need the table.' 'That is fine. But - are you all right?' The man looks at him. Something in his face changes. 'Not really,' he says.

Joe comes back after his break. The man is still there. Joe puts a fresh glass of water on the table. 'Thank you. You are kind.' Then: 'I am Martin.' 'Joe.' Something changes between them. 'Martin, what are you waiting for?' Martin looks at the street. 'Someone,' he says. 'Someone I lost.'

'We met here. At this table. Twenty years ago.' 'She sat here.' He puts his hand on the chair across from him. 'We talked for three hours. I did not want to go.' 'What happened?' 'Life. Different cities. We lost contact.' 'And now you come here every morning.' 'Yes. This is the last place I saw her. So I come here.'

'What is her name?' Joe asks. 'Lena.' Martin says it very quietly - like the word is something delicate. 'Do you know where she is now?' 'No. I tried to find her. No address. No phone number. Just her name and this café.' 'Just her name.' Joe thinks. 'And you come here every day.' 'Yes. I think - I hope - she remembers too. Maybe one day she comes back here.'

Joe tells Dana about Martin and Lena. 'That is very sad. But also very sweet.' 'Does he have a photo of her?' Dana asks. The next morning, Joe asks. Martin opens his bag and takes out an old photograph. A young woman. Dark hair. Big smile. Standing outside this café. 'This is Lena,' Martin says.

Dana looks at the photograph for a long time. 'Joe. Come here.' Dana shows him the photo. Then she points to the door. A woman is standing at the door. About fifty. Dark hair - a little grey now. She looks nervous. Dana shows Joe the photo again. Then she looks at the woman. Joe understands. He does not move. He does not speak.

The woman walks in. She looks at the tables. She looks at the window. Then she sees table seven. She sees Martin. Martin is looking at the street. He does not see her yet. Lena puts her hand on her heart. She takes a breath. Then she walks to table seven. Martin turns his head. His glass of water falls. For a long time, they just look at each other.

'Martin.' Her voice is small. Martin stands up. His chair makes a noise. He does not care. 'Lena.' Just her name. 'I came back,' Lena says. 'I came to

The Man at Table Seven



Joe and Dana study an old photograph behind the counter.

find you - or just to sit here. I did not think-' 'I am here every morning,' Martin says. 'Every morning for three months.' Lena's eyes are wet. 'Three months?' 'Three months,' Martin says. He smiles for the first time.

Joe and Dana stand behind the counter and watch. Martin and Lena sit at table seven and talk for a very long time. Joe brings them coffee without asking. Lena looks up and smiles. 'Thank you.' 'Of course.' He goes back to the counter. He feels very good. 'You see?' Dana says quietly. 'Not yet. But sometimes not yet becomes today.'

Martin and Lena are still at table seven at two in the afternoon. Joe finishes his morning shift. He puts on his jacket. Martin is talking. Lena is listening. Then Lena is talking. Martin is listening. Three cups of coffee each. Joe smiles. He waves at Dana and walks out. Outside, the city is loud and busy. But Joe feels quiet inside.

At seven forty-five, Joe looks at the door. Martin comes in - but today, he is not alone. Lena is with him. They walk to table seven. Martin looks happy - different from yesterday. 'Good morning, Joe,' Martin says. 'Good morning. The usual? Two waters?' Martin laughs - a real, warm laugh. 'No.

Today we want coffee. And something to eat.'

In the weeks after that, Martin and Lena come to the café together - not every day, but often. Sometimes Martin comes alone. He sits at table seven, but now he reads a book and drinks coffee. Lena sometimes comes alone too. She always says hello to Joe and Dana. Table seven is still their table. Joe thinks: a table can be just a table. Or it can be a place where a story begins.

One quiet morning, Joe is alone before the café opens. He looks at table seven. He thinks about Martin - three months of waiting, just water, just hope. Joe is twenty-eight. He has a girlfriend named Suki. They are fine. But they do not talk like Martin and Lena. Joe takes out his phone and writes: 'Are you free this evening? I want to take you somewhere nice.' He sends it. Then he opens the café.

That evening, Joe takes Suki to a small Italian restaurant near the river. They eat pasta. They drink wine. They talk - really talk - for three hours. On the way home, Suki holds Joe's hand. 'You are different today.' 'I met someone at work. He taught me something.' 'What?' Joe thinks for a moment. 'That waiting for someone is good. But

The Man at Table Seven



Martin and Lena meet again at table seven.

talking to them is better.'

Two months later, Martin comes alone. 'Coffee today?' 'Yes please. I have news. Good news.' 'Lena and I are leaving London. She has a house in the countryside. I am going with her.' 'That is wonderful.' Martin looks at Joe. 'I want to say thank you. You asked if I was all right. Nobody asks that. It was a small thing. But it helped.'

Martin drinks his coffee slowly. He looks at the table, the window, the street. 'Do you know what is funny? I came every day for three months. I was afraid. What if she never comes? What if nothing happens?' 'But you came anyway,' Joe says. 'Yes.' Martin stands and puts on his coat. 'You have to try. You have to be there. That is all.' He shakes Joe's hand. A real, strong handshake. 'Goodbye. Take care of table seven.'

Martin walks out into the morning street. Joe watches until he is gone. Then he looks at table seven. The coffee cup is there. The chair is empty. A young woman comes in. She sees table seven - near the window, in the light. 'Can I sit here?' 'Of course. That is a good table.' Joe smiles and goes to make her coffee. Table seven waits - ready for the next story.

Story Vocabulary

The words below are collected from the story. They are given together so the reading pages stay like a real story book.

1. wipes	siler	2. always	her zaman
3. leather	deri	4. glass	bardak
5. looks out	dışarıya bakar	6. puts on	giyer
7. leaves	ayrılır	8. waiting for	... beklemek
9. street	cadde	10. shrugs	omuz silker
11. not yet	henüz değil	12. excuse me	afedersiniz
13. sorry	özür dilerim	14. just need	sadece ihtiyacı var
15. not really	pek sayılmaz	16. still	hâlâ
17. fresh	taze	18. kind	nazik
19. lost	kaybettiği	20. met	tanıştı
21. across from	karşısında	22. lost contact	iletişimi kesti
23. last place	son yer	24. quietly	sessizce
25. delicate	narin	26. tried to find	bulmaya çalıştı
27. remembers	hatırlar	28. hope	ummak
29. sweet	duygusal, tatlı	30. photo	fotoğraf
31. dark hair	siyah saç	32. outside	dışarıda
33. points to	işaret eder	34. nervous	gergin
35. move	hareket etmek	36. understand	anlamak

37. takes a breath	derin nefes alır	38. turns his head	başını çevirir
39. falls	düşer	40. each other	birbirlerine
41. does not care	umursamaz	42. wet	ıslak, yaşlı
43. three months	üç ay	44. smiles	gülümser
45. without asking	sormadan	46. feels good	kendini iyi hisseder
47. becomes	dönüşür	48. shift	vardiya
49. waves	el sallar	50. loud	gürültülü
51. busy	kalabalık	52. alone	yalnız
53. different	farklı	54. usual	her zamanki
55. laughs	güler	56. warm	sıcak, samimi
57. together	birlikte	58. often	sık sık
59. regular	düzenli müşteri	60. story begins	hikâye başlar
61. girlfriend	kız arkadaş	62. fine	iyi, fena değil
63. free	müsait	64. sends	gönderir
65. river	nehir	66. holds	tutar
67. taught	öğretti	68. better	daha iyi
69. news	haber	70. countryside	kırsal
71. wonderful	harika	72. helped	yardımcı oldu
73. afraid	korkmuş	74. anyway	yine de
75. handshake	el sıkışma	76. take care of	... ile ilgilen
77. empty	boş	78. gone	gitmiş
79. ready	hazır	80. next story	bir sonraki hikâye

After-Reading Activities

1. Vocabulary Practice - Match the Words

Match each word with the correct meaning.

1. waits
- A. gülümser
2. empty
- B. bekler
3. nervous
- C. boş
4. smiles
- D. gergin
5. leaves
- E. nazik
6. kind
- F. ayrılır
7. afraid
- G. korkmuş
8. wonderful
- H. harika

2. Fill in the Blanks

Choose the correct word from the box and write it in the blank.

alone - empty - nervous - street - waiting - careful

1. Martin sits at table seven and looks at the _____.
2. When Lena comes in, she looks _____.
3. After Martin leaves, table seven is _____.
4. Martin comes to the café _____ for three months.
5. Joe and Dana stand behind the counter and watch - they do not say anything, they are _____.
6. Martin was _____ but he came every day anyway.

3. Comprehension Questions

True or False? Write T or F.

1. Martin comes to the café every evening. ____
2. Martin always orders coffee. ____
3. Martin and Lena met at this café twenty years ago. ____
4. Dana finds Lena on the internet. ____
5. Martin waits for three months. ____
6. At the end, Martin and Lena move to the countryside. ____

Short Answer Questions

7. Where does Martin always sit?
8. What does Martin always order?
9. Why does Martin come to the café every morning?
10. How does Dana help?
11. How long does Martin wait before Lena comes?
12. What does Martin teach Joe?
13. What does Joe do after his conversation with Martin?
14. What is Martin's news at the end?
15. What does Martin say to Joe before he leaves?

Answer Key

(Alıştırırmaları yaptıktan sonra bakınız.)

Match: 1-B 2-C 3-D 4-A 5-F 6-E 7-G 8-H

Fill in the Blanks: 1. street 2. nervous 3. empty 4. alone 5. careful 6. afraid

True / False: 1. F 2. F 3. T 4. F 5. T 6. T

7. Table seven, near the window.

8. Only water.

9. He met Lena there twenty years ago and hopes she will come back.

10. She recognises Lena from the photograph when Lena walks in.

11. Three months.

12. That talking to the people you care about is important.

13. He takes his girlfriend Suki to a restaurant and they really talk.

14. He and Lena are leaving London to live in the countryside.

15. He says thank you and tells Joe to take care of table seven.